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Preface

This year the ENTER conference will be celebrated for the 16th time. Founded in 1993 as an interface between information and communication technologies on the one side and travel and tourism on the other, ENTER has steadily matured to become the world's premier global conference in this fascinating and constantly advancing and progressing area of research and praxis.

The aim and unique purpose of ENTER is to bring together practitioners from the travel and tourism industry, representatives from national and regional tourism boards, and academics and researchers from different disciplines to facilitate the exchange and joint development of new ideas, innovative approaches and advanced solutions. Therefore, research findings presented at ENTER always have a strong relationship and relevance to problems faced by the industry.

Information and communication technologies have reshaped the travel and tourism industry in the last decade and new topics and corresponding challenges are evolving rapidly. The dynamic nature of tourism markets has become ever more pronounced and innovative business models like online communities continue to emerge. ENTER 2009 pays attention to this situation and the theme *eTourism: dynamic challenges for travel and tourism* expresses the objective to present a collection of cutting-edge academic and industrial research as well as practical applications dealing with new challenges and new ways of doing business in a rapidly changing and highly dynamic environment.

Over 70 papers have been submitted to ENTER 2009 and the finally selected 42 papers were double blind reviewed by members of the scientific committee. These high quality papers cover a wide range of cutting-edge topics currently driving research and development activities in the field of IT and travel & tourism. Under the topic *online communities* papers deal with the virtualisation of travel communities and experiences as well as the driving forces of online communities within travel and tourism. The topic *user generated content* deals with travel reviews and blogs and their influence and importance within the travel decision making process. The topic *recommender systems* covers papers presenting approaches for knowledge-based decision support and their acceptance under tourism-specific settings. The topic *mobile technology* presents analysis results and practical applications in the area of mobile services and tourist guides. The topic *platforms and tools* covers presentations of several innovative IT tools and their applications in the tourism domain. In the age of online distribution, *website optimisation* is a fundamental aspect and papers in this section discuss different approaches for measuring and improving the performance of tourism websites. The topic *electronic marketing* investigates in more detail specific aspects of using the Internet to market tourism services like affiliate marketing and email communication. Papers in the section *ICT and tourism destinations* especially focus on the application of techniques and approaches mentioned above in the context of tourism destinations as amalgams of different tourism suppliers and stakeholders. The section *technology acceptance* concludes the range of topics by presenting

research results in the areas of technology acceptance and adoption in the travel and tourism industry.

The ENTER paper submission process, following the objective of quality assurance and quality improvement, is a challenging process both for authors and members of the programme review committee and the success of the ENTER research track strongly depends on such input and support. Therefore, the research track chairs would like to thank all the members of the review committee for their continuous support of the ENTER review process and their dedication to ENTER, which has spanned in many cases already more than a decade. And, of course, we would like to thank all authors for their valuable input and effort. A high quality ENTER programme is nothing else than a collection of single high quality papers, written by experienced researchers all over the world.

ENTER is especially characterised by a worldwide community of individuals from all parts of the travel and tourism industry and different research disciplines, coming together once a year to discuss latest trends and developments in this challenging area. We would like to thank all ENTER attendees for their continuous support of ENTER and wish all of us a successful and joyful ENTER 2009 in Amsterdam.

Wolfram Höpken

Ulrike Gretzel

Rob Law

Amsterdam, January 2009

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